Yang Berbahagia Dato' Peter Ng,
UCSI University Council chairman

Yang Berbahagia Assoc Prof Dr Mabel Tan Hwee Joo
UCSI College, president and CEO

Yang Berusaha Siti Riniy Fariza Mohd Borham,
National Cyber Security Agency principal assistant director, Prime Minister Office

Yang Berusaha Dr Tatchapol Poshyanonda,
Palo Alto Networks (Asean), country director

Yang Berusaha Azuin Baharudin
AceTeam Networks, executive chairman

Yang Berusaha Wan Roshaimi Wan Abdullah,
Cyber Security Malaysia CTO

Members of UCSI's top management team, distinguished guests, dear colleagues, ladies and gentlemen,

Assalamualaikum warahmatullahi wabarakatuh, salam sejahtera and Salam Malaysia Madani. Welcome to UCSI University. Welcome to our first Hackathon.

It's nice to see so many of you today. I'm made to understand that over 400 participants - and more than 100 teams - are putting their hacking abilities to the test today. Their mission: Hack a secure Palo Alto cloud platform and find as many flags as they can. To the participants, embrace the challenge and rise to the occasion. But try not to do too much damage in the process okay? That's a joke. Today is all about ethical hacking. Go give it your best shot!

In many ways, today's Hackathon exemplifies the significance of the Information Age -

an age of unprecedented connectivity. Our dependence on cyberspace has never been greater. Literally everything is connected - our hardware and software, our desktops and laptops, our cell phones and cloud storage. Cyberspace keeps our power grids running. It's the backbone of our business, banking and financial systems. And it props up the military and intelligence networks that keeps Malaysia safe.

But herein lies the great irony: The very technologies that empower us to create and innovate also enable those who seek to mislead, harm and destroy - rogue actors, organised crime syndicates and even state actors. This paradox is something that takes place every moment. We know them by their many names - malware, spyware and ransomware to name a few. In 2019, we saw how the NotPetya malware attack on a single line of code outed Maersk's global IT network. On top of affecting the world's largest shipping company, the attack crippled port operations, paralysed corporations and brought the shipping industry to a standstill. And operations only resumed after Maersk paid a king's ransom of US$300 million.

In Malaysia alone, Cyber999 has recorded over 3,000 reported cyber threats so far in 2024. And these attacks target critical sectors from the airline industry to telecommunications. AirAsia, TM, Prasarana, Media Prima… many of Malaysia's biggest companies have suffered cyber attacks and data breaches. However, most Malaysian companies remain underprepared, with only 2% of companies achieving a "mature" level of cybersecurity readiness.

Ladies and gentlemen,

Much more needs to be done. And it is encouraging to see Malaysia moving in the right direction. The Government passed the Cybersecurity Act 2024 in August, highlighting the need to safeguard national critical information infrastructure. To ensure the best deterrents are in place, only qualified entities will be authorised to provide cybersecurity

services. To meet Malaysia's 25,000 cyber defender target, 12,000 new jobs will be created and cybersecurity analysts, penetration testers and cloud security specialists will be in high demand. The Malaysian cybersecurity market is set to grow from RM0.95 billion in 2023 to a whopping RM2.06 billion by 2028 - an incredible opportunity for skilled professionals.

In this context, today's hackathon is both timely and timeless. By testing their wits, mastery of code and IT skills, today's participants are preparing themselves to rise up as the cybersecurity experts of tomorrow. I hope the 16 to 18-year-olds in attendance will be inspired to further their studies in cybersecurity. And if this is indeed your desire, all of us at UCSI would like to hear more from you.

Before I conclude, I would like to extend my heartfelt thanks to Palo Alto Networks and AceTeam Networks for their sponsorship of today's event. Your support went a long way in making this event a success and what will, I'm sure, become a great and challenging competition. I would also like to congratulate Asst Prof Ts Dr Raenu and his team for their hard work in realising this Hackathon.

To our participants today, do your best and enjoy the experience. I am confident that all of you will do very well.

Thank you.